



POLITICIANS LIKE RAJ THACKERAY ARE UNAPOLOGETIC ABOUT THEIR POLITICS OF HATRED

such brotherhood ideas were loudly proclaimed. The Americans weren't listening and didn't care. The only time America did say, "What's going on here?" was in December of 2001, when some Lashkar people showed up in jeeps to blow up our Parliament and we said we might go to war.

As the decade rolled on, there were surprises, disappointments, optimism, shame, joy, elation and apologies, but none predictable. The sudden rise (and complete domination of) the Congress party from a position of relative weakness made pundits look foolish and made the BJP's India Shining slogan work against them as India shone essentially to, and for, the Congress. Even though an economic rise was guessed, 8 per cent GDP or thereabouts as Europe shrunk, elated us and generated a lot of chat about the rise of a new India and its consuming power. A young nation gained confidence from earning and spending much sooner than their parents did, call centre jobs and a visit from President Bush ("We love you" our prime minister said). And the poster child of this new India, certainly post elections, was Rahul Gandhi, proving his dexterity at balancing convoluted patriarchal alliances with new-age consultant thinking, all the while carrying his charm with the good looks of a Turkish lothario.

THE WHOLE WRETCHED thing of money for votes is a classic example of wrong decision making. L.K. Advani was at the centre of this whole drama.

JASWANT SINGH, MP

Some things came as no surprise: politicians held up bags of money in Parliament exposing bribes they said were offered to switch affiliation. This came some years after a news organisation held covert operations (coined "sting" to sound forceful I suppose) to expose a shocking new reality. Politicians caught on camera taking bribes in suitcases. A large debate ensued about the venal and barbaric nature of the elected corrupt while those accused defended themselves

by a) claiming they were set up, b) threatening and shutting down the news organisation in question or c) trying to slither out through petty detail loopholes. To the public, there was never any debate on whether our elected officials take bribes. It was certainty. What we refer to as everyday. The only sting operation that would have indeed shocked the people was if our politicians didn't take a bribe.

Later, a news channel did another sting operation exposing the movie actor Shakti Kapoor asking for sexual favours in return for giving a young lady a film role thereby starting a debate on Bollywood's casting couch. Again, the only shock for the nation here was that Shakti Kapoor sleeps with women.

Any highlight of these past 10 years would be incomplete without mentioning last year's events in Mumbai. Arguably, the logic and procedure had antecedents across the world and, therefore, it should have been no

shock when men in their 20s with guns and backpacks showed up to kill and die. Yet it was. Beyond of course, the shock of what they did was the shock of who we were. A crumbling city with inadequate security, a foolish elite incapable of erudite opinion, an intelligentsia with no political voice, an elite paralysed in its own elitism. This decade showed we needed to wake up, even if we had no idea what the hell to, where to go or what to ask for.

Unfair PRACTICES

2001 Operation West End, a sting operation catches the then BJP president Bangaru Lakshman accepting bribes to approve defence contracts.

2005 Anti-Muslim riots in Gujarat follow the Godhra carnage where a train carrying Hindu pilgrims is set on fire. The state government is accused of conspiracy.



2005 External affairs minister Natwar Singh resigns after he is named in Oilgate, the Iraqi food-for-oil scam.

2005 Eleven MPs are expelled from Parliament after a sting operation shows them accepting cash for asking questions in the House.

2006 The birth of Maharashtra Navnirman Sena ramps up the use of violence against north Indians as a political tool. The party wins 13 seats in the 2009 Assembly polls.



2009 The CBI raids the Department of Telecom, alleging a Rs 20,000-crore fraud in spectrum allocation.